The Story Behind Your Story

Key Verse: "For my thoughts are not your thoughts, neither are your ways my ways, saith the LORD. For as the heavens are higher than the earth, so are my ways higher than your ways, and my thoughts than your thoughts." — Isaiah 55:8–9 (KJV)

There is a story you have been telling about yourself for as long as you can remember. It is the story of your failures and your victories, your wounds and your recoveries, your sins and your virtues. You have rehearsed it so many times that it has become the truth itself—not merely a version of the truth, but the whole of it. You know the chapters by heart. You know where the plot turns, where the tragedy lies, where the redemption, if any, begins. You have appointed yourself both narrator and judge of your own life. But what if you are telling the wrong story? What if the story you tell about yourself is rarely the story God is telling?

This is not a small matter. It is not a minor adjustment to your self-image. It is a complete reordering of reality. God speaks through the prophet Isaiah with words that should stop us cold: "For my thoughts are not your thoughts, neither are your ways my ways." He does not say they are slightly different. He does not say they are an improvement upon ours. He says they are as far removed as the heavens are from the earth. The distance is not one of degree but of kind. We are not merely shortsighted; we are looking in the wrong direction entirely.

Consider Joseph. If you had asked him, in the pit, in the prison, in the forgotten years of faithful service to a jailer who never remembered him, to tell his story, what would he have said? He would have said: I am the forgotten son. I am the betrayed brother. I am the dreamer whose dreams have died. Every fact of his life supported that narrative. His brothers stripped him. Potiphar's wife lied about him. The butler forgot him. The evidence was overwhelming. His testimony was one of injustice and abandonment. But God was telling a different story. God was telling the story of a deliverer being prepared. Every pit was a classroom. Every prison was a palace in waiting. Every forgotten year was a forging of character that could not be rushed. Joseph could only see the back of the tapestry—the tangled threads, the apparent chaos. God was weaving a masterpiece on the other side. And when Joseph finally stood before his brothers, he did not say, You ruined my life. He said, "But as for you, ye thought evil against me; but God meant it unto good, to bring to pass as it is this day, to save much people alive" (Genesis 50:20). He had learned to read his life through God's narrative, not his own.

Consider the woman at the well. Ask her to tell her story, and she would have said: I am the woman with five husbands. I am the one who comes to the well at noon to avoid the eyes of others. I am the shame of my village. That was her testimony—accurate in every detail, and utterly incomplete. Jesus did not deny her past. He named it. But He did not let it be the final word. He gave her a new story: I am the woman who met the Messiah. I am the one who left her waterpot and ran to tell the city. Her old testimony was true. Her new testimony was truer still. And the difference was not in the facts but in the Author. This is the great danger of our self-told stories: they are not lies. They are half-truths, which are far more dangerous. We take the raw material of our lives—real sins, real wounds, real failures—and we weave them into a narrative that makes sense to us. But our sense-making is fallen. Our interpretation is limited. We see through a glass darkly, and we mistake the darkness for the whole room.

Peter knew this. He knew his own story. He was the one who denied Christ three times. He was the one who cursed and swore that he never knew the man. If you had asked Peter to give his testimony after the resurrection, he might have said: I am the failure. I am the one who broke. I am the denier. And every word would have been true. But Jesus did not let Peter's version stand. Three times He asked, "Simon, son of Jonas, lovest thou me?" Three times Peter said yes. Three times Jesus said, Feed my sheep. He was not erasing the denial. He was rewriting it. Peter's failure became the very ground of his restoration. His weakness became the doorway through which grace entered. His old story was the crucifixion. His new story was the resurrection. And he could not have written it himself.

This is what God does. He takes our testimonies—the stories we tell about ourselves, the stories we are sure are true—and He reframes them. He does not deny the facts. He does not pretend the wounds are not real. But He places them in a larger story, a story with a different ending, a story where the Author has authority over every chapter. Think of Jacob, the deceiver, wrestling with God and walking away with a limp and a new name. Think of Moses, the murderer, becoming the deliverer of Israel. Think of David, the adulterer, becoming the man after God's own heart. Think of Paul, the persecutor, becoming the apostle. Think of Rahab, the harlot, becoming the ancestor of Christ. Every one of them had a testimony. Every one of them was wrong. Not factually wrong—they had indeed done those things and suffered those things—but narratively wrong. They had placed themselves at the center of the story. God was always the center.

"For as the heavens are higher than the earth, so are my ways higher than your ways, and my thoughts than your thoughts." This is not a rebuke. It is a comfort. It means that your story is not finished. It means that the chapters you thought were the end are not the end. It means that the Author is still writing, and He does not write tragedies. He writes redemption stories, every time. But let us go deeper still, for there is a layer beneath this layer that we have not yet touched. The reason we tell the wrong story is not merely that we are mistaken. It is that we are fallen. Our self-narration is not innocent. It is shaped by pride, by fear, by the need to justify ourselves. When we tell our story, we are always, in some sense, defending ourselves. We are building a case. We are presenting evidence. We are seeking a verdict. And the verdict we seek is always the same: I am not as bad as I seem. I am not as guilty as they say. I am, on the whole, a decent person who has been dealt a difficult hand.

But God's verdict is different. "There is none righteous, no, not one: There is none that understandeth, there is none that seeketh after God. They are all gone out of the way, they are together become unprofitable; there is none that doeth good, no, not one" (Romans 3:10–12). This is not the story we tell. This is the story God tells. And until we accept His version—until we stop defending ourselves and start agreeing with Him—we cannot be saved. For salvation is not the improvement of our story. It is the death of our story and the resurrection of His. This is why the gospel is so offensive. It does not say, You have made some mistakes; let me help you fix them. It says, You are dead in trespasses and sins (Ephesians 2:1). It says, Your righteousness is as filthy rags (Isaiah 64:6). It says, There is no health in you (Psalm 38:3). These are not exaggerations. They are the truth. And the truth is that the story we tell about ourselves—the story of our basic goodness, our reasonable decency, our understandable failures—is a lie. It is the lie that keeps us from the cross. It is the lie that keeps us from grace.

For if I am fundamentally good, why do I need a Savior? If my story is essentially fine, why does it need to be rewritten? The cross is only precious to those who know they deserve hell. The resurrection is only powerful to those who know they were dead. And so the first step in hearing God's story about us is to stop telling our own. It is to put our hand over our mouth. It is to fall silent before the Author. "Be still, and know that I am God" (Psalm 46:10). Only when we are silent can we hear His voice. And what is His voice saying? What is the story He is telling about us? He is saying: You were chosen before the foundation of the world (Ephesians 1:4). He is saying: You were predestined to be conformed to the image of my Son (Romans 8:29). He is saying: You were bought with a price (1 Corinthians 6:20). He is

saying: You are my beloved child, in whom I am well pleased (Matthew 3:17). He is saying: Nothing can separate you from my love (Romans 8:38–39). He is saying: I will never leave you nor forsake you (Hebrews 13:5). He is saying: I have begun a good work in you, and I will complete it (Philippians 1:6).

This is your story. Not the story of your failures. Not the story of your wounds. Not the story of your sin. Those things are real, but they are not the final word. The final word is grace. The final word is redemption. The final word is resurrection. The final word is Christ. And so we must learn to read our lives through His eyes. This is what it means to have the mind of Christ (1 Corinthians 2:16). It means that we no longer interpret our suffering as abandonment—we interpret it as discipline, as preparation, as the shaping of our character. It means that we no longer interpret our failures as identity—we interpret them as opportunities for grace to abound. It means that we no longer interpret our lives as our own—we interpret them as His. "I am crucified with Christ: nevertheless I live; yet not I, but Christ liveth in me: and the life which I now live in the flesh I live by the faith of the Son of God, who loved me, and gave himself for me" (Galatians 2:20).

This is the story God is telling. It is the story of Christ in you, the hope of glory (Colossians 1:27). It is the story of a life that is no longer yours, lived for a purpose that is no longer yours, heading toward an ending that is not an ending at all but a beginning. Your testimony is not your testimony. It never was. It is His. And He is telling a better story than you could ever tell about yourself. He is telling a story of redemption so thorough, so complete, so devastating to the powers of sin and death, that the angels themselves long to look into it (1 Peter 1:12). He is telling a story where every tear is wiped away, every wound is healed, every wrong is made right, and every chapter—even the darkest ones—serves the glory of the Author. So put down your pen. Stop writing your story. Stop defending yourself. Stop explaining yourself. Stop narrating your own life as though you were the center of it. And listen. Listen to the voice of the One who has been writing your story from before the foundation of the world. Listen to the voice of the One who knows the ending from the beginning. Listen to the voice of the One who has written your name in the palm of His hand (Isaiah 49:16). "For I know the thoughts that I think toward you, saith the LORD, thoughts of peace, and not of evil, to give you an expected end" (Jeremiah 29:11). That is your story. That is your testimony. Not what you have done, but what He has done. Not where you have been, but where He is taking you. Not who you were, but who He is making you. Your testimony is not your testimony. It is His. And it is better than anything you could have written.